BEYOND CHIAVARI · FREE PLANNING KIT

Holiday Party Planning Kit

Office and home holiday parties, from Friendsgiving through New Year's, with Chicago winter logistics

December is the busiest month for event bookings in the Chicago area, and the weather adds its own challenges. This kit helps you lock in a date early, plan food and drinks, and handle coats, snow, and parking so the party feels easy for your guests.

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Chairs, tables, linens, tents and more across Chicagoland, on one quote.

PART 1

Planning Timeline

For parties between Thanksgiving and New Year's, start in September or early October.

10 to 12 weeks out (September)

- [ ] Decide the type of party: office party, family gathering, Friendsgiving, neighborhood open house, or New Year's Eve.
- [ ] Pick two or three possible dates and avoid the busiest weekends if you can, such as the first and second Saturdays in December.
- [ ] Set a total budget and a per-guest target.
- [ ] Reserve a venue, restaurant room, or banquet space, or confirm your home hosting plan.
- [ ] Request quotes for rentals now, since tables, chairs, linens, and glassware book up in December.
- [ ] Book caterers, bartenders, or a food truck before their calendars fill.

7 to 9 weeks out

- [ ] Create the guest list and note plus-ones, kids, and dietary needs.
- [ ] Send a save-the-date by email or text.
- [ ] Choose a theme: classic, cozy, winter white, glam, or ugly sweater.
- [ ] Book DJ, live music, or plan a playlist.
- [ ] Plan photo moments such as a backdrop or photo booth.
- [ ] Ask a friend or coworker to join a small planning committee.

4 to 6 weeks out

- [ ] Send formal invitations with an RSVP deadline.
- [ ] Finalize the menu and drink list with your caterer or shopping plan.
- [ ] Order rentals: chairs, tables, linens, dinnerware, glassware, and lounge furniture.
- [ ] Plan decor and order lights, centerpieces, and table decor.
- [ ] Plan a gift exchange or white elephant if you want one.
- [ ] Check office policies on alcohol, hours, and guests.

2 to 3 weeks out

- [ ] Follow up on RSVPs and update your headcount.
- [ ] Plan coat check or a coat rack area, and boot trays for snowy days.
- [ ] Plan parking: street, lot, valet, or rideshare drop-off.
- [ ] Confirm rental delivery and pickup windows.
- [ ] Confirm vendors' arrival times and menus.
- [ ] Buy nonalcoholic drinks, ice, and paper goods if self-catering.

The week of

- [ ] Give the final headcount to the caterer and rental company.
- [ ] Check the forecast and plan for snow removal, salt, and shoveled paths.
- [ ] Do a walk-through of the space and plan where coats, food, and drinks will go.
- [ ] Prep make-ahead dishes and label them.
- [ ] Send a reminder to guests with address, parking, and start time.
- [ ] Charge speakers and test lights and music.

Day of and after

- [ ] Set up tables and chairs at least 2 hours before guests arrive.
- [ ] Salt the entrance and keep a mat and towels at the door.
- [ ] Put out food in stages and refresh as needed.
- [ ] Arrange safe rides home for guests who need them.
- [ ] Return or ready rentals for pickup.
- [ ] Send thank-you messages and share photos.

PART 2

Party Type Checklist

OFFICE PARTY

- [ ] Confirm budget and approval with leadership or HR.
- [ ] Choose a time that works for different shifts or remote teams.
- [ ] Plan inclusive food, drinks, and activities for all backgrounds.
- [ ] Offer nonalcoholic options and clear end times.
- [ ] Arrange for a gift exchange or recognition moment if appropriate.
- [ ] Plan rides home or transit information.
- [ ] Collect dietary needs by survey before ordering food.

HOME HOLIDAY PARTY

- [ ] Set a guest limit based on your space and fire safety.
- [ ] Plan coat storage, such as a bed or a rack.
- [ ] Clear walkways and add runners for wet floors.
- [ ] Set up a drink station away from the kitchen.
- [ ] Plan trash and recycling bins.
- [ ] Let neighbors know about the party and parking.
- [ ] Move fragile decor and breakables out of walkways.
- [ ] Check that smoke alarms work and exits are clear.

FRIENDSGIVING AND THANKSGIVING

- [ ] Pick the date, often the weekend before or after Thanksgiving Day.
- [ ] Assign dishes so you do not end up with five pies.
- [ ] Rent extra tables and chairs for a longer table.
- [ ] Plan for vegetarian and allergy-friendly options.
- [ ] Keep the oven and stovetop schedule on a sheet.
- [ ] Ask guests to bring their own containers for leftovers.
- [ ] Borrow or rent a second oven-safe warmer or chafing dishes.

NEW YEAR'S EVE

- [ ] Plan the midnight toast and glassware.
- [ ] Provide nonalcoholic sparkling options.
- [ ] Arrange safe transport and overnight options.
- [ ] Set up a countdown clock or screen.
- [ ] Plan late-night snacks.
- [ ] Prepare a cleanup plan for the morning after.
- [ ] Set a clear plan for sleeping arrangements or rides before the first drink.

PART 3

Winter Logistics Checklist

Chicago winters are unpredictable. A little planning keeps guests warm and safe.

COATS AND ENTRY

- [ ] Set up a coat rack or coat check with numbered tickets.
- [ ] Place boot trays and mats at the door.
- [ ] Provide a towel station for wet shoes.
- [ ] Have a place for umbrellas and hats.
- [ ] Assign a helper to greet guests and take coats.

SNOW AND PARKING

- [ ] Shovel and salt the walkway before guests arrive.
- [ ] Check city parking rules, including winter overnight bans and snow routes.
- [ ] Share rideshare drop-off instructions and an alternate parking option.
- [ ] Add a snow date or a flexible start time if the forecast is severe.
- [ ] Light the entrance and path clearly after dark.
- [ ] Keep a shovel and salt near the door in case of a late snowfall.

HEAT AND COMFORT

- [ ] Check the heating system a week before the party.
- [ ] Plan for crowd warmth, since packed rooms heat up fast.
- [ ] Add extra seating for older guests.
- [ ] If using a tent, ask about heaters and sidewalls.
- [ ] Plan warm drinks such as cider, cocoa, and coffee.
- [ ] Keep a first aid kit and basic medicines nearby.

BOOKING CRUNCH

- [ ] Call venues and rental companies as early as September for December dates.
- [ ] Ask caterers whether December has minimums or higher rates.
- [ ] Book rideshare codes, shuttles, or a valet before the busiest weekends.
- [ ] Have a backup date or a smaller-version plan if a vendor cancels.
- [ ] Order decor, lights, and supplies early to avoid shipping delays.

PART 4

Food and Drink Amounts

Rough guidelines for a 3 to 4 hour party. Adjust based on whether you serve a meal or appetizers.

Item	20 guests	40 guests	75 guests	100 guests
Appetizers (pieces, if no meal)	120 to 160	240 to 320	450 to 600	600 to 800
Main dishes (entrees)	20 to 24 portions	40 to 48 portions	75 to 90 portions	100 to 120 portions
Sides and salads	3 to 4 dishes	4 to 5 dishes	5 to 6 dishes	6 to 8 dishes
Desserts	30 to 40 pieces	60 to 80 pieces	110 to 150 pieces	150 to 200 pieces
Wine bottles (if serving)	6 to 8	12 to 16	22 to 30	30 to 40
Beer (cans or bottles)	30 to 40	60 to 80	110 to 150	150 to 200
Nonalcoholic drinks	40 to 60	80 to 120	150 to 225	200 to 300
Coffee and hot drinks	1 large urn	2 large urns	3 large urns	4 large urns
Ice	20 lbs	40 lbs	70 lbs	100 lbs

Item	20 guests	40 guests	75 guests	100 guests
Plates, napkins, cutlery	2 per guest	2 per guest	2 per guest	2 per guest
Chairs	12 to 20	25 to 40	45 to 75	60 to 100

PART 5

Budget Split

Rough starting shares. Office budgets often have a fixed per-person cap.



Category	Share	Your budget: $_____	Tip
Food and catering	38%	$_____	Heavy appetizers and stations can be a lower-cost alternative to a plated dinner.
Drinks and bar service	18%	$_____	A signature cocktail plus beer and wine reduces cost.
Venue or space	12%	$_____	Weeknight and daytime dates are often more affordable than weekend nights.
Rentals (tables, chairs, linens, glassware)	12%	$_____	Book early, since December inventory moves fast.
Decor and lighting	8%	$_____	String lights, greenery, and candles can have a big impact at a small cost.
Music and entertainment	6%	$_____	A curated playlist and speaker can work for smaller parties.
Staffing, coat check, and parking help	3%	$_____	Even one helper at the door makes arrival smoother.
Invitations and favors	2%	$_____	Digital invitations are often enough.
Contingency	1%	$_____	Set aside a little for extra ice, salt, or last-minute needs.

PART 6

Tips for a Smooth Holiday Party

- Book your venue and rentals before Halloween if you can. December weekends are the first to fill.
- Pick an off-peak date such as a weeknight or an early December weekend for better availability.
- Put a snack or small bite out early so guests are not hungry while they wait for dinner.
- Make a quiet corner for guests who want a break from the noise.
- Place drinks in more than one location to avoid lines.
- Add a nonalcoholic option that feels festive, like a cider or a mocktail.
- Plan for the unexpected with extra chairs, ice, and napkins.
- Ask a friend to be the cleanup captain so you can enjoy the party.

PART 7

Party Worksheet

PARTY TYPE AND DATE

START AND END TIME

VENUE OR ADDRESS

EXPECTED GUEST COUNT

CATERER OR FOOD PLAN

BAR AND DRINKS PLAN

RENTAL COMPANY AND DELIVERY WINDOW

COAT STORAGE PLAN

PARKING PLAN

SNOW PLAN

MUSIC PLAN

TOTAL BUDGET

NEXT STEP

Get every rental on one quote

Pick chairs, tables, linens, dinnerware, tents and decor from Chicago-area rental companies and see prices as you build your list at beyondchiavari.com/quote. Want a second set of eyes on your plan? Book a free planning call at beyondchiavari.com/book.

Planning rules of thumb only. Confirm counts, rules and timing with your venue and vendors. © Beyond Chiavari. Free to print and share for personal planning.